Under a Spell

Grace, not law, both received the Galatians into Christ and sustains them in Christ — so Paul's five questions expose the folly of turning from grace to law at every stage of the Christian life.

Where this study fits

Galatians · sixteen studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 The Ground of Liberty	**02** 1:6–10 The One True Gospel	**03** 1:11–17 Paul's Independent Revelation	**04** 1:18–2:10 Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches
05 2:11–21 Peter Goes Back to School	**06** 3:1–5 Under a Spell	**07** 3:6–14 Blessing or a Curse	**08** 3:15–29 The Superiority of the Promise to the Law
09 4:1–11 When I Became a Man	**10** 4:12–20 A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove	**11** 4:21–31 Paul's Old Testament Story	**12** 5:1–12 Taking a Stand in Liberty
13 5:13–26 Walk in the Spirit	**14** 6:1–5 Brothers and Burdens	**15** 6:6–10 Sowing and Reaping	**16** 6:11–18 Teaching the Truth

Five questions for foolish Galatians

Galatians 3:1–5 · The commentary's outline

v.1	Precedence — Christ crucified was placarded before them by grace first	**προεγράφη** posted up publicly
v.2	Procedure — they received the Spirit by the hearing of faith	**ἀκοῆς πίστεως** faith from what is heard
v.3	Perfection — begun by the Spirit, not finished by the flesh	**ἐπιτελεῖσθε** being made complete
v.4	Persecution — returning to law would empty their suffering of meaning	**εἰκῇ** in vain, to no purpose
v.5	Promotion — the Spirit's supply and miracles came by faith	**ἐπιχορηγῶν** lavish, ongoing supply

Foolish, bewitched — and Christ placarded

Galatians 3:1 · Outline I — The precedence of Christianity

1 “O foolish Galatians”

ἀνόητοι
Not demented — simply not using the sense God gave them

2 “Who has bewitched you?”

ἐβάσκανεν
Hyperbole: who put a hex on you? Their turn made no sense

3 “Clearly portrayed”

προεγράφη
Posted publicly, like a placard — in preaching, baptism and the Table

4 “As crucified”

ἐσταυρωμένος
Perfect participle — Christ stands permanently as the crucified One

How did you receive the Spirit?

Galatians 3:2 · Outline II — The procedure of Christianity

	By the works of the law?	By the hearing of faith ✓
What it is	Deeds done in obedience to the Mosaic code	Believing the message that was heard
Greek	ἔργων νόμου	ἀκοῆς πίστεως — faith arising from what is heard
The result	No — the Spirit never came this way	Yes — salvation and the Spirit at the same moment

Salvation and the reception of the Spirit are simultaneous, though not synonymous. Some 33 things happen the moment a person believes (Chafer).

Begun in the Spirit — finished in the flesh?

Galatians 3:3 · Outline III — The perfection of Christianity

Having begun
πνεύματι by the Spirit

- The Christian life starts with the Spirit, received by faith

Now made perfect?
ἐπιτελεῖσθε Pres. Mid./Pass.

- An attempted, ongoing “finishing” project

By the flesh?
σαρκί self-effort

- Human effort in place of grace

“By one offering He has perfected forever those who are being sanctified” (Hebrews 10:14).

Suffering and supply

Galatians 3:4–5 · Outline IV–V — Persecution and promotion

Persecution — v.4
ἐπάθετε · εἰκῇ suffered · in vain

- They suffered for the gospel from the start
- “We must through many tribulations enter the kingdom” (Acts 14:22)
- Going back to law would make it all for nothing

Promotion — v.5
ἐπιχορηγῶν Pres. Act. Ptc.

- God keeps supplying the Spirit — lavishly
- Miracles among them, e.g. the lame man at Lystra (Acts 14:8–10)
- By the hearing of faith, not works of the law

Ongoing power comes the same way salvation did — by faith.

Discuss and apply

Galatians 3:1–5 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. What does it mean that receiving the Spirit and being saved are simultaneous but not synonymous?

2. Explain in your own words the difference between your perfection and your practice (3:3).

Apply

Trade Trying for Trusting
Tell God out loud today that you are trusting Him rather than trying to earn the outcome yourself.

Let Your Practice Catch Up to Your Perfection
Practice one habit this week as a response to being accepted — not as an attempt to become accepted.

In one line: What began by grace through faith continues by grace through faith.